## 4.2 Nutrition and aging

The study of the nutritional needs of aging people is complicated by the fact that the older the people, the more complex the nutritional needs from both a social and physiological point of view.

Geriatrics the branch of medicine dedicated to the care of the aging as well as an aged is concerned with expanding the length of the prime period of life delay in the onset of severely degenerative aspects of ageing, and reading the disease of the aged.

### 4.2.1 Factors affecting the intake of food

As with any age group the nutritional adequacy of the diet of the elderly is the result of variety of factors that determine dietary intake, the utilisation of nutrients and finally the nutrient requirements. All of these factors include environmental as well as biological considerations. The major influences on nutrient intake, use and in need are summarised in Table 4.2

**Table 4.2 Factors affecting food intake, nutrient utilization, nutrient needs of elderly**

| | Food Intake | Nutrient Utilization | Nutrient needs |
|---|---|---|---|
| Physical | Loss of teeth<br>Lack of neuromuscular coordination<br>Impaired hearing and vision<br>Physical weakness and disability<br>Immobility<br>Discomfort on ingestion of certain food | Immobility | Body composition, Decreased activity. |
| Physiological | Loss of sense of taste and smell<br>Anorexia (lack of appetite) | Decreased salivation<br>Decreased enzyme activity<br>Decreased gastric activity<br>Depressed gastric motility<br>Depressed kidney function<br>Chronic disease<br>Malabsorption<br>Decreased hormonal secretion | Use of drugs, Decreased metabolic efficiency. |
| Social | Long standing food habits<br>Food preferences<br>Beliefs about effects of food<br>Economic considerations<br>Susceptibility to food misinformation<br>Failure to adapt to new environment | Meal pattern | |
| Psychological | Living alone<br>Depression<br>Anxiety | Anxiety | |



UNIT_4_ Adult and Old age.indd 75 25-02-2019 15:34:08